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原生恆星盤外圍絲狀結構之模型與觀測比較
Modeling Streamer Structures in Collapsing
Prestellar Cores

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摘要

Streamers have been observed with high-resolution ALMA observations around many protoplanetary disks undergoing formation. They have been suggested to dominate the mass accretion budget from the collapsing prestellar core, and have important consequences on the disk dynamics. Understanding the formation of streamers is therefore important for explaining how protoplanetary disks receive mass from the envelope. We propose a model to explain the formation of streamer structures by considering density enhancements due to gravitational instability. We test our model against sources where streamers have been detected (ex., Per-emb-2 and Per-emb-50 observed with NOEMA) and fit for model parameters. This allows us to gain deeper insights into the physical origin of streamers and their role in mass transport from the core to the disk. This model can be applied to analyze new observations as well as archival data that show signs of streamers.

Abstract

Streamers have been observed with high-resolution ALMA observations around many protoplanetary disks undergoing formation. They have been suggested to dominate the mass accretion budget from the collapsing prestellar core, and have important consequences on the disk dynamics. Understanding the formation of streamers is therefore important for explaining how protoplanetary disks receive mass from the envelope. We propose a model to explain the formation of streamer structures by considering density enhancements due to gravitational instability. We test our model against sources where streamers have been detected (ex., Per-emb-2 and Per-emb-50 observed with NOEMA) and fit for model parameters. This allows us to gain deeper insights into the physical origin of streamers and their role in mass transport from the core to the disk. This model can be applied to analyze new observations as well as archival data that show signs of streamers.

Contents

Abstract (Chinese)	I
Abstract	II
Contents	III
List of Figures	V
List of Tables	VI
1 Introduction	1
1.1 The formation of cores	1
1.2 The streamer in observations	2
1.3 Observations	3
1.3.1 Per-emb-2	4
1.3.2 Per-emb-50	4
1.3.3 SVS 13A	4
1.3.4 S CrA	4
1.3.5 HL Tau	4
1.4 Our work overview	4
2 Methods	5
2.1 Build up a model	5

2.2	Formalism	5
2.3	Coordinate transformation	6
2.4	Streamer on the sky in the PPV space	7
2.5	Fitting procedure	7
2.5.1	Position angle	7
2.5.2	Extracting the position and velocity from observations . . .	8
2.5.3	Grid search parameter estimation	9
2.5.4	Markov Chain Monte Carlo exploration	10
2.5.5	Fitting with partially known parameters	11
3	Results	12
4	Discussion	13
5	Conclusion	14
A	Observations	15
	Bibliography	16

List of Figures

List of Tables

A.1 Observations	15
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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 The formation of cores

Stars form within cold, dense regions of molecular clouds, where local density enhancements can initiate gravitational collapse. Once a sufficiently overdense region begins to contract, it forms a dense core, a gravitationally bound structure that represents the earliest stage of star formation. Before any central heating source develops, the collapsing dense core is referred to as a prestellar core, characterized by low temperatures (~ 10 K) and the absence of an internal heat source.

As the collapse proceeds and densities rise, the gas eventually becomes optically thick to its own radiation. At this point, radiative cooling becomes inefficient, and the collapse slows as the pressure begins to increase adiabatically. This transition leads to the formation of the first hydrostatic core (FHSC), which is a short-lived structure supported primarily by adiabatic pressure. The FHSC phase lasts only a few thousand years and marks a key evolutionary stage between the prestellar core and the protostellar core.

When the temperature in the center increases to ~ 2000 K, molecular hydrogen begins to dissociate, a process that absorbs energy and reduces thermal pressure support. This triggers a second, rapid collapse and gives rise to the protostar,

the central object that continues to grow by accreting material from its surrounding envelope. Although accretion from the envelope begins during the prestellar and FHSC stages, the protostar phase formally begins once the second collapse produces a gravitationally bound central object.

The envelope surrounding the forming protostar is a cold, dusty reservoir of infalling material. It typically extends over thousands to tens of thousands of AU, and in the earliest stages the envelope retains a large fraction of the system’s mass.

During the early Class 0 and Class I stages, the protostar remains enshrouded within this parental envelope. In this turbulent and gravitationally unstable environment, small perturbations within the envelope can grow nonlinearly, giving rise to asymmetric, filamentary overdensities known as streamers. These streamers represent dense structures within the infalling envelope and, unlike the rotationally supported disk, do not necessarily follow Keplerian motion. They are increasingly recognized as an important channel for transporting material from the envelope onto the disk, thereby influencing disk growth, stability, and angular-momentum redistribution.

Over time, as accretion weakens and the envelope dissipates, the protostar evolves into a pre-main-sequence star, eventually contracting toward the main sequence where sustained hydrogen fusion begins.

1.2 The streamer in observations

Recently, several observations revealed asymmetric structures in the protostellar system (e.g., Pineda et al. 2020, Valdivia-Mena et al. 2022, Hsieh et al. 2023). The features of streamers are very diverse in morphology, do not always form in a disk plane, and have very weak density enhancement in observation.

1.3 Observations

To test our model against sources where streamers have been detected, we use five observational datasets: Per-emb-2, Per-emb-50, S CrA, HL Tau, and SVS 13A. The Per-emb-2, Per-emb-50, and SVS 13A were observed by the Northern Extended Millimeter Array (NOEMA). Per-emb-2 was observed in D-configuration on June 22, July 27-28, and August 19, 2018, and in C-configuration on October 9, 10, 17, and 18 (project S18AG, Pineda et al. 2020). The baseline values ranged from 16.4 to 287.8 meters. Per-emb-50 was observed in C-configuration on December 29, 2019, and January 5, 2021, and D-configuration on August 6, September 7, and 8, 2020 (Valdivia-Mena et al. 2022). SVS13A was also observed using two different configurations: C-configuration on December 29, 2019, and January 5, 2020, and in D-configuration on August 6 and September 7, 2020. The baseline range is between 15.6 and 368 meters, corresponding to a synthesized beam size of $1.''2 \times 0.''7$ (Hsieh et al. 2023). The S CrA, HL Tau were observed by Atacama Large Millimeter/submillimeter Array (ALMA). The S CrA observation data from ALMA Science Archive was observed on November 6, 2019 (Project 2019.1.01792.S, Gupta et al. 2023). HL Tau was observed by ALMA's C40-7 array configuration on August 22, 28, and September 1, 2017. The maximum projected baseline length is 3.3 km (Yen et al. 2019). For each source, we extract the position-position-velocity (PPV) data of the streamer.

1.3.1 Per-emb-2

1.3.2 Per-emb-50

1.3.3 SVS 13A

1.3.4 S CrA

1.3.5 HL Tau

1.4 Our work overview

The formation process of protoplanetary disks is still unrefined. Given their importance, we have developed a new model to characterize the streamer features and kinematics, focusing on gravitationally driven infalling and rotation.

Chapter 2

Methods

2.1 Build up a model

We build a model that can reproduce the observed streamer by considering a self-collapse density enhancement structure with a rotation velocity and evolve with time in 3D space.

2.2 Formalism

In the formalism, including the density enhancement along the polar angle (θ), infall velocity (v_{inf}), rotation velocity (v_{rot}), accumulated rotation (ϕ), and inclination (i). The sonic length.

$$r_s = c_s T \quad (2.1)$$

Infall velocity

$$v_{\text{inf}} = -\sqrt{\frac{2GM_*}{r}} - 3.3c_s \quad (c_s = 200m/s) \quad (2.2)$$

The rotation velocity.

$$v_{\text{rot}} = r_s \omega \Omega_{\text{kep}} \left[\left(\frac{r}{r_s} \right)^{-1} + \left(\frac{r}{r_s} \right)^{-\frac{1}{3}} \right] \quad (2.3)$$

The accumulated rotation.

$$\phi = \phi_0 + t_s \omega \Omega_{\text{kep}} \sqrt{\frac{2c_s^3 t_s}{GM_*}} \left[\left(\frac{r}{r_s} \right)^{-\frac{1}{2}} + \left(\frac{r}{r_s} \right)^{-\frac{1}{3}} \right] \quad (2.4)$$

2.3 Coordinate transformation

Position

$$\begin{cases} x = r \sin \theta \cos \phi \\ y = r \sin \theta \sin \phi \\ z = r \cos \theta \end{cases} \quad (2.5)$$

Infall velocity

$$\begin{cases} v_{x_{\text{inf}}} = v_{\text{inf}} \sin \theta \cos \phi \\ v_{y_{\text{inf}}} = v_{\text{inf}} \sin \theta \sin \phi \\ v_{z_{\text{inf}}} = v_{\text{inf}} \cos \theta \end{cases} \quad (2.6)$$

Rotation velocity

$$\begin{cases} v_x = -v_{\text{rot}} \sin \theta \sin \phi + v_{x_{\text{inf}}} \\ v_y = v_{\text{rot}} \sin \theta \cos \phi + v_{y_{\text{inf}}} \\ v_z = 0 + v_{z_{\text{inf}}} \end{cases} \quad (2.7)$$

2.4 Streamer on the sky in the PPV space

Position rotates by inclination. Inclination(i): backward (+), forward (-).

$$\begin{cases} x' = r \sin \theta \cos \phi \\ y' = y \cos i + z \sin i \\ z' = -y \sin i + z \cos i = r(-\sin \theta \sin \phi \sin i + \cos \theta \cos i) \end{cases} \quad (2.8)$$

Velocity rotates by inclination

$$\begin{cases} v'_x = v_x \\ v'_y = v_y \cos i + v_z \sin i = v_{rot} \sin \theta \cos \phi \cos i + v_{inf}(\sin \theta \sin \phi \cos i + \cos \theta \sin i) \\ v'_z = -v_y \sin i + v_z \cos i = -v_{rot} \sin \theta \cos \phi \sin i + v_{inf}(-\sin \theta \sin \phi \sin i + \cos \theta \cos i) \end{cases} \quad (2.9)$$

θ corresponds to the initial polar angle of the streamer, ϕ_0 is the initial azimuth angle, i is the inclination angle (zero inclination corresponds to an edge-on disk), ω is the ratio of Keplerian rotation velocity, and t_s is the collapsing time of the particle within the streamer.

2.5 Fitting procedure

The fitting procedure described below is applied to each dataset to constrain the model parameters. The results are compared to the observed streamer morphology and kinematics to assess the validity of the model.

2.5.1 Position angle

[(YN) This step can be neglected if the disk PA on the sky is known. Otherwise, the previous step needs to be repeated until the optimal is

found.]

2.5.2 Extracting the position and velocity from observations

To characterize the observed streamer structure, we extract position and velocity centroids as a function of projected radius from the data cube. Starting from the masked streamer cube, we define a sequence of radial bins extending along the approximate direction of the streamer. The radial coordinate (r) and polar angle (θ) of each pixel relative to the protostar are computed in the image plane, and an initial reference $\theta(r)$ profile is obtained from a smoothed interpolation of visually identified streamer pixels.

For each radial bin, we compute the centroid position using an intensity-weighted average that favors pixels aligned with the local streamer direction. Specifically, we calculate a directional weight

$$w_\theta = \exp \left[-\frac{(\theta - \theta_{\text{ref}}(r))^2}{2\sigma_\theta(r)^2} \right],$$

where $\theta_{\text{ref}}(r)$ is the interpolated streamer direction and $\sigma_\theta(r)$ is derived from the local spatial dispersion of the preliminary centroids. The position centroid ($\bar{x}$, $\bar{z}$) within each radial bin is then computed from

$$\bar{x} = \frac{\sum I w_\theta x}{\sum I w_\theta}, \quad \bar{z} = \frac{\sum I w_\theta z}{\sum I w_\theta},$$

where I is the data cube intensity at each pixel.

The velocity centroid for each radial bin is computed in the same region using

$$\bar{v} = \frac{\sum I w_\theta v}{\sum I w_\theta},$$

where v is the channel velocity converted to the LSR frame. This procedure yields a set of 11 position-velocity centroids $(\bar{x}(r), \bar{z}(r), \bar{v}(r))$ that trace the observed streamer morphology. These centroids represent a compact, noise-suppressed summary of the streamer trajectory and are used both in the grid search and in the fast-likelihood MCMC analysis.

2.5.3 Grid search parameter estimation

We model the streamer kinematics using five parameters $(\theta, \phi_0, i, t_s, \omega)$, corresponding to the initial polar and azimuthal angles of the streamer, the inclination of the system, the characteristic collapse time, and the ratio of rotation velocity. For each target, we first perform a coarse five-dimensional grid search to identify reasonable regions of parameter space. The grid covers $\theta \in (0, \pi/2)$, $\phi \in (0, 2\pi)$, and $i \in (-\pi/2, \pi/2)$ with uniform sampling, while the collapse time t_s is sampled logarithmically around a characteristic dynamical timescale set by the Keplerian period at a reference radius, and ω is sampled linearly between 0 and 1.

The grid search uses the same 11 streamer centroids extracted from the data to evaluate the model performance. At each grid point, we compute the misfit between the model streamer and the observed streamer centroids using the error metric

$$E = \sqrt{\langle \Delta x^2 + \Delta z^2 + w_v \Delta v^2 \rangle},$$

where Δx and Δz are the differences in projected position (in AU), and Δv is the corresponding line-of-sight velocity residual (in km s^{-1}) for each of the measured centroids. The weight

$$w_v = \left(\frac{\Delta x_{\text{AU}}}{\Delta v_{\text{km s}^{-1}}} \right)^2$$

is chosen such that spatial and velocity deviations contribute in comparable physical units.

2.5.4 Markov Chain Monte Carlo exploration

After constructing data-driven prior ranges from the grid search, we perform Markov Chain Monte Carlo (MCMC) exploration of the five parameters. The MCMC sampling is carried out using the `emcee` package, which implements an affine-invariant ensemble sampler that efficiently explores correlated and multi-modal parameter distributions.

We use the grid results to construct the priors for the subsequent MCMC exploration. Specifically, we select all grid models with $E \leq (1 + f) E_{\min}$, where $E_{\min}$ is the minimum grid misfit and f is typically 0.05–0.10 (relaxed if necessary to include at least several tens of models). For each parameter we take the 5th–95th percentile range of these “good” models and pad this interval by $\sim 30\%$ to define a broad, uniform prior. This procedure yields data-driven prior bounds that are wide enough to avoid artificially constraining the solution but narrow enough to exclude clearly disfavored regions of parameter space.

Each MCMC run begins by initializing an ensemble of walkers within the prior intervals, distributed in a narrow region around the best-performing grid-search solution. For the likelihood function based on the 11 position and velocity centroids, we typically use $N_{\text{walkers}} = 20$ and $N_{\text{steps}} = 2 \times 10^4$, initializing the walkers around the best grid solution but clipping them to the prior ranges. This “fast-likelihood” stage provides an efficient refinement of the parameter space and helps to identify the dominant modes of the posterior distribution.

For the full datacube likelihood, we evaluate the agreement between the model and the observed Position-Position-Velocity structure using a shell-based distance metric. Instead of computing distances for every voxel, the method constructs a shell-distance cube around the model streamer and compares it with the data cube through intensity-weighted shell distances. For this shell-based likelihood, we adopt $N_{\text{walkers}} = 20$, and $N_{\text{steps}} = 8 \times 10^3$. This stage allows the MCMC to probe

the global three-dimensional structure while remaining computationally tractable and provides a more restrictive, global constraint on the model parameters.

Convergence of the chains is evaluated using the autocorrelation time of each parameter, as well as visual inspection of walker trajectories. An initial burn-in phase is discarded, and the remaining samples are used to compute posterior medians and credible intervals as the final estimates of the five parameters.

2.5.5 Fitting with partially known parameters

Chapter 3

Results

Chapter 4

Discussion

Chapter 5

Conclusion

Appendix A

Observations

Table A.1: Observations

Target	RA (J2000) (h m s)	Decl (J2000) (° ' ")	Stellar mass ($M_{\odot}$)	Systemic velocity (km/s)	Disk inclination	Disk position angle	Reference
Per-emb-2	03 : 32 : 17.9320	30.49.47.7050	3.2				1
Per-emb-50	03 : 29 : 07.7680	31.21.57.1280	2.58		67°	170°	2
HLTau	04 : 31 : 38.4280	18.13.57.1900	2.1	7.14	47°	°	3
S CrA	19 : 01 : 08.6000	−36.57.20.0000	2	5.86	65°	°	4
SVS 13A	03 : 29 : 03.7400	31.16.03.8000			°	°	5

Note The inclination angle with $i=0$ corresponds to a face-on disk. **References**

⁽¹⁾Pineda et al. 2020 ⁽²⁾Valdivia-Mena et al. 2022 ⁽³⁾Yen et al. 2019 ⁽⁴⁾Gahm et al. 2018 ⁽⁵⁾Hsieh et al. 2023

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